



FLEET & SHORE PERSONNEL TRAINING

Questions and Answers

The agreed lines to take when the media ask difficult questions about the Company, the fleet and the crew.



Media Handling

Navigate Response

Standard Response Statements

Company SMS

The subjects the media will raise

01

The Company and Its Fleet

Ownership, financials, responsibility and age

04

Policies on Board

Drugs, alcohol, smoking and compensation

02

Standards, Class and Inspections

Management systems, class, port State control

05

Navigation and Security

Pilots, passage planning and the ISPS Code

03

Officers and Crew

Recruitment, nationality, training and flag

06

Standard Response Statements

A worked example and its follow-up releases

HOW TO USE THIS SET

A starting point, not a script for every incident

This generic set of questions and answers might help get you started. Navigate Response will work up a tailored set of Q&A to suit the specific incident.

Generic set

Tailored set follows

Never improvise



SECTION 01

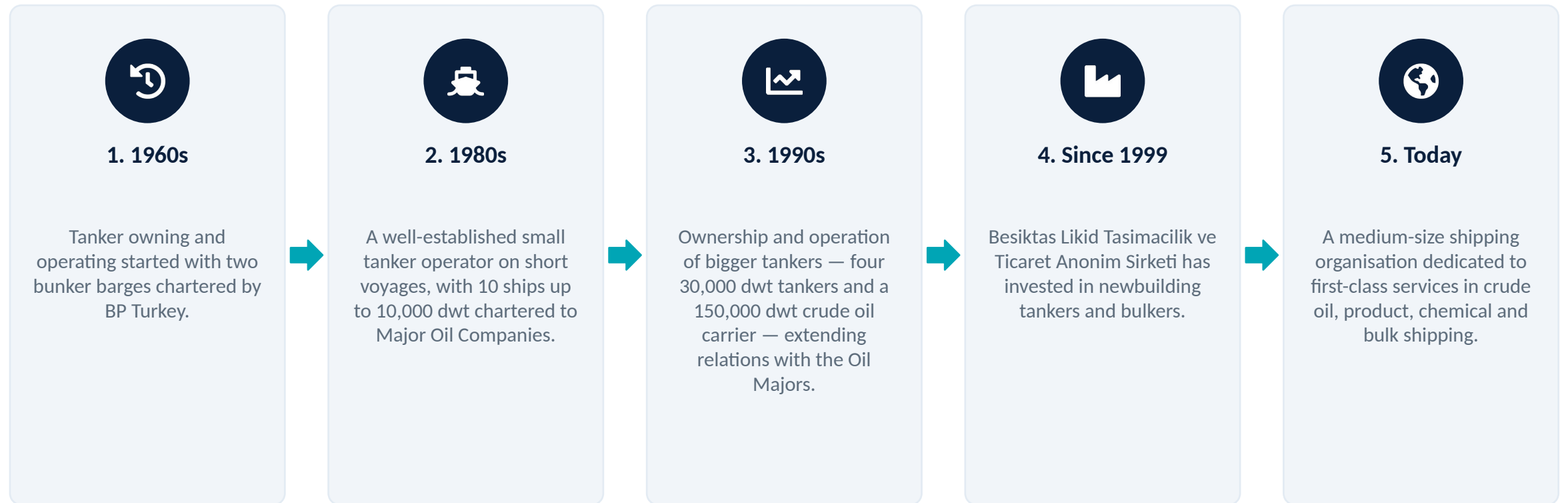
The Company and Its Fleet

Questions about ownership, published accounts, who carries responsibility, and the age of the ships.

01

Can you explain the ownership structure of your Company?

The agreed answer is the history of the business, told in five stages.



The three points to land in any ownership answer



Continuity

The best value of the Company is being a tanker owner and operator since the 1960s. Today it is the most traditional tanker company of Turkey.



Quality of service

A medium-size organisation dedicated to first-class services in crude oil, product, chemical and bulk shipping.



Standing with the Oil Majors

Tank vessels have been chartered to Major Oil Companies since the 1980s, and those relations were extended through the 1990s.

Two short answers that must not be expanded

These questions are usually asked to open a longer conversation. Give the agreed answer and stop there.

Question	Agreed answer
Are there any accounts published for your Company? If so, where can the accounts be seen?	No.
In the event of a casualty, who takes responsibility — the ship manager, the owner or the Master?	The ultimate responsibility for the vessel lies with the ship manager. However, this does not mean that the ship manager is necessarily responsible for the incident.
Do you accept full responsibility for all casualties on your owned, managed or operated fleet, and for those for which you only act as agent?	We will manage the casualty to the best of our ability and fully comply with any subsequent investigation of an incident by either the flag State or the Administration, to ensure that any lessons are learned.

Your vessels are now beginning to age. How can you justify that?

The agreed answer opens with "that's untrue" and then gives the numbers.

2011

Build year of the latest vessel to join the fleet

2005

Build year of the oldest vessel in the fleet

Zero

Detentions recorded across the fleet



Age alone proves nothing — Age is not a reliable indicator of a vessel's condition. What matters is its ability to meet all port State requirements and to trade safely — and our vessels meet those criteria.



Older vessels are watched harder — Older vessels are placed under much more rigorous scrutiny and inspection, which is an additional assurance rather than a risk.



The record speaks — There have been no detentions amongst our fleet, which indicates the high standards to which we operate.

Do you worry about the massive claims following casualties?

Potential environmental claims could far exceed the cover. Answer on insurance, on operating standards, and stop.



Insurance

- We have the maximum insurance cover that is available in the market
- Do not put a figure on the cover
- Do not discuss costs — they involve insurance considerations



Prevention

- No ship operator trades worldwide expecting their vessels to be involved in a major pollution incident
- Because of the type of cargoes we carry, our ships are run to a high standard
- Highly trained, experienced crews are carried to prevent any harm whatsoever to the environment



Not for discussion

- The likely size of any claim
- Liability or blame for the incident
- The cause of the incident, which will be the subject of an enquiry



SECTION 02

Standards, Class and Inspections

Management systems, classification societies, port State control, Paris MOU and detentions.

02

Who is responsible for the management systems on board?

The agreed answer has four parts, and all four should be given.



We are responsible

The Company is responsible for the management system on board our vessels. Responsibility is not delegated to a third party.



Class approved

A class-approved safety management system is in place on our vessels.



Full scope

Our Safety Management System covers safety, health, security, environmental and operational aspects.



Audited annually

Our Safety Management System is internally and externally audited every year.



The ISM question

Asked whether lower standards of compliance are applied anywhere — for example where port State control is less rigorous — the answer is no. The standards we have set meet the requirements of the most rigorous port State scrutiny, and those standards are the same regardless of port.

The integrity of some classification societies has been questioned

The owner is also the customer. Answer on membership, on convention recognition, and on what that guarantees.



Membership and ethics

- Our classification societies are members of the International Association of Classification Societies
- They comply with the IACS code of ethics



Recognised in convention

- The role of classification and of classification societies is recognised in the International Convention for the Safety of Life at Sea (SOLAS)
- It is also recognised in the 1988 Protocol to the International Convention on Load Lines, plus the 2003 Amendments
- These ensure standards are maintained at a high level

Do you pay classification societies to conduct your surveys?

Yes — and the answer explains why that does not create a conflict of interest.



Yes, we pay them

We pay classification societies to conduct surveys and inspections. There is nothing to conceal in saying so.



They act as a Recognised Organisation

This does not lead to a conflict of interest, because the classification society is acting as a "Recognised Organisation" (RO), responsible and accountable to the flag Administration.



Delegation is permitted by convention

SOLAS and other international conventions permit the Administration to delegate the inspection and survey of ships to an RO.



The RO is itself audited

The RO is subject to certification of its quality system by an independent body of auditors accepted by the Administration.

Port State Control, Paris MOU and Equasis

Question	Agreed answer
A number of Port State Inspections recorded deficiencies on your vessel. Is that symptomatic of poor shipmanagement?	We do not have low standards, or a poor record, as a ship manager. Most, if not all, shipping companies will have vessels with deficiencies recorded against them. Like any large and complex piece of machinery, things will occasionally need to be replaced. It is the job of Port State Inspections, and of the crew, to highlight these and to ensure repairs are made when needed.
The Paris MOU and Equasis databases show reported deficiencies and even some detentions. How can you claim to run a quality operation?	Port State Control has subjected ships to ever increasing scrutiny in recent years and all shipping companies will find increased deficiencies and detentions. Our deficiency rate is kept to a minimum, and there has been no detention.
How can you say you run a quality operation if your vessel has been detained by Port State Control?	This has never been faced within our operation. Deficiencies are always immediately rectified. There are very few shipping companies in existence that have not had a vessel detained at some time or other, and we are one of them.

THE LINE ON STANDARDS

We do not have low standards, or a poor record, as a ship manager

Deficiencies are a normal feature of port State inspection across the industry. What distinguishes a quality operation is that they are found, recorded and rectified immediately.

Found

Recorded

Rectified immediately



SECTION 03

Officers and Crew

Recruitment, nationality, promotion, training and the flags the ships fly.

03

Does your Company employ "crews of convenience" to cut costs?

No. Crews are employed on published criteria, and the answer sets those out.



Valid certification

Crews are employed on the basis of their valid certification for the rank they will hold.



Ability to speak English

The working language requirement is applied at recruitment, not afterwards.



Relevant experience

Past experience on the type of vessel on which they are employed.



One nationality, our own manning

All of our crew members are of the same nationality — Turkish — and are manned by our own company.



Certificates verified

Certifications are checked for verification via the Turkish Ministry of Transport, Maritime Affairs and Communication.



Wages and cadets

We pay good rates of wages to our crew, and we employ approximately 25 apprentices (cadets).

Communication, race and outsourcing

Question	Agreed answer
Can mixed nationality officers and crews lead to communication problems?	All of our crews are Turkish.
Do you operate a racist crewing policy? Do any of your crew members from developing nations become Captains?	We do not operate a racist crewing policy. When a senior position becomes available, promotion is awarded to the officer with the best credentials, regardless of race, creed, skin colour or religious persuasion.
Do you outsource your crewing? Does this not mean lower standards?	No.

How do you recruit and train your crews?

1

Recruited by our own department

Our experienced crewing department recruits our crews. We would only select those who have all the required certification and who have completed all training courses required for their rank.

2

Familiarisation is a procedure, not a courtesy

Because of the very high standard required on board by the type of cargoes we carry, procedures are established within our Safety Management System to ensure proper familiarisation of the crew with all safety and operational aspects appropriate to each rank.

3

Drills and training sessions

Regular drills and training sessions are held, covering all aspects of safety and counter-pollution measures.

Are you supporting an operation that encourages lower standards?

The answer names the registries and explains what the white list actually means.



What we never do

- We would never support or encourage lower standards on our vessels
- Flag choice is not a route to lower standards



The registries we use

- Turkey
- Malta
- Marshall Islands
- All three are open registries on the same white list



What the white list means

- Inclusion on the white list depends on the registry adopting all major International Maritime Organization (IMO) conventions
- It is therefore a measure of convention compliance, not of cost



SECTION 04

Policies on Board

Drugs, alcohol, smoking and the one subject we do not discuss at all.

04

Enforcement, testing and control

Three questions are commonly asked together. Answer each one plainly.



On what basis do you rely on the Master?

The Master is the Company's representative on board the vessel. He is fully aware of the Company drug and alcohol policy and of our expectations.



Who tests the Master?

The Chief Officer.



Do you ban alcohol like other owners?

We do not ban alcohol consumption on board our vessels; however, consumption of alcohol is strictly controlled as per our Drug and Alcohol Policy and procedures.



Do you test after ports?

Alcohol and drug tests are carried out on all personnel after each port.

What is permitted on board, and what is not

Asked about the smoking policy of a tanker company, the answer is short and absolute. The same applies to alcohol: controlled, not banned.



PERMITTED

- Smoking in the officers' hall
- Smoking in the personnel hall
- Consumption of alcohol on board, strictly controlled as per our Drug and Alcohol Policy and procedures
- Testing: alcohol and drug tests are carried out on all personnel after each port



NOT PERMITTED

- Smoking in cabins — strictly prohibited
- Smoking anywhere else on board
- Consumption of alcohol outside the limits set by the Drug and Alcohol Policy and procedures
- Any elaboration on how the policy is enforced against an individual

Two questions with very short answers

Both answers are complete as written. Give them and move on — length is what creates the risk here.



Compensation

Will you compensate the relatives of the crew following a casualty? Does that mean you accept responsibility?

We do not discuss crew compensation matters. This answer is given in full and nothing is added to it — any elaboration will be read as an admission of liability.



ISM Code

Are there circumstances where you apply lower standards of compliance — for example where Port State Control is less rigorous?

No. The standards we have set meet the requirements of the most rigorous port State scrutiny. These standards are the same regardless of port.



Why they stay short

- Discussing costs could involve insurance considerations
- Discussing blame or liability pre-empts the enquiry
- Any elaboration will be quoted as the Company position
- Refer anything further to Navigate Response



SECTION 05

Navigation and Security

The role of the pilot, how passages are planned, and what we will and will not say about security.

05

The Master always remains in charge of the vessel, even when a pilot is on board

Asked who is to blame when a ship runs aground — the Master or the pilot — this is the whole of the agreed answer. Do not speculate on the cause of any particular grounding.

No speculation

No apportioning of blame

The enquiry will decide

What happens on your ships with regard to passage planning?

Every aspect of the passage envisaged from berth to berth is considered through a risk assessment of hazards and waypoint selection.



Berth to berth

The plan covers the whole passage, including pilotage areas and contingency plans.



Hazards recorded in the plan

T&P Notices, no-go areas and emergency anchorages must be included in the passage plan.



Appraisal against the manual

Appraisal should be made of all relevant information available on board, as required by our Shipboard Operation Navigation Manual.



Exchange 24 hours before ETA

An information exchange initiated by the ship approximately 24 hours before the pilot's ETA allows sufficient time for more detailed planning both on the ship and ashore, and establishes communications with the pilot station before embarkation.



The forms to be used

Ship-to-Shore Master/Pilot Exchange (NAV OPS 19) and Shore-to-Ship Pilot/Master Exchange (NAV OPS 20) forms should be used for this purpose.

What plans do you have to protect your vessels?

We do not discuss the practical arrangements for on-board security. These are the points that can be given.



Ship security plan

The ship security plan on all of our vessels provides guidance and instruction on the security measures to be adopted during all aspects of normal operations.



Training and drills

Regular training in security matters is given to all crew, and regular security drills are held on board.



Company Security Officer

The Company Security Officer provides the ships with the latest information regarding worldwide threats to shipping.



ISPS compliance

All our vessels, and the Company as a whole, comply with the ISPS Code.



Attack is harder now

Any attack is harder since the introduction of the International Ship and Port Facility Security Code.



Commercial, not military

We are a commercial, not a military, operation. We remain vulnerable to terrorist or bandit attack but are vigilant about such matters at all times.

What may be said, and what must never be said

Security is the one subject where detail itself is the risk. Keep to the published framework.

✓ SAY

- That a ship security plan is in place on all of our vessels
- That regular security training and drills are held on board
- That the Company Security Officer supplies the latest worldwide threat information
- That all vessels and the Company comply with the ISPS Code

⊘ NEVER SAY

- Anything about the practical arrangements for on-board security
- The content of any ship security plan
- Details of measures in force at any particular port or on any particular voyage
- Any assessment of how a specific vessel would respond to an attack



SECTION 06

Standard Response Statements

A worked example of an initial response statement, and the elements of the releases that follow it.

The facts an initial response statement must carry

An example of an initial response statement to an incident involving a Besiktas Group vessel. Every figure is verified before it is used.

0825h

Time of the incident, GMT

163,750

Deadweight tonnage of the
motor tanker

11

Miles north-west of Terschilling,
North Sea

135,000

Tonnes of Arabian Light crude oil
on board



What happened — At 0825h GMT today the 163,750 dwt motor tanker Besiktas xxxxxxxx, operated by Besiktas Shipping Group, was in collision with another vessel about 11 miles north-west of the Dutch island of Terschilling in the North Sea.



The cargo and the voyage — The Besiktas xxxxxxxx is on charter to and is carrying a cargo of 135,000 tonnes of Arabian Light crude oil loaded in Saudi Arabia and destined for the refinery at Harburg.

What the rest of the initial statement says



The spill, qualified

It is reported that some oil has been spilled as a result of the collision. Initial reports suggest the quantity spilt to date does not exceed [...] tonnes.



Who we are talking to

Besiktas Shipping Group is in contact with charterer and with the Dutch authorities who are responding to the accident.



What we have offered

The Group has offered assistance in terms of expertise and equipment.



The commitment to update

There will be further statements when more information is available. Examples of the elements of subsequent press releases follow.



Fill every bracket

Square brackets and rows of dots mark facts that must be verified and inserted before release. A statement issued with a placeholder still in it is worse than no statement at all.

By Besiktas Shipping Group, as owner of the vessel

Two elements are used in the follow-up releases where the vessel is owned by a Besiktas Shipping Group company, and one clearance rule applies to both.



Re pollution

We very much regret all damage to the environment which may be caused by this incident. Priority is being given to preventing any further spillage of cargo. We are liaising with local and national authorities [preferably named] and together have mobilised the necessary resources to combat the pollution.



Re claims

We are concerned that no one suffers unnecessary hardship. Arrangements are being made for claims to be handled by [.....], telephone [.....].



Before it goes out

Every bracketed placeholder must be replaced with a verified name, number or figure. The text is then cleared with Group contacts and circulated to the designated spokespersons.

By Besiktas Shipping Group, as ship managers

Where the Group acts as ship manager, the wording goes further on legal responsibility and gives the public an enquiry number.



Re pollution

- We greatly regret this accident and its consequences
- We currently estimate that to date [...] tonnes of [.....] oil have been spilt to the sea
- Priority is being given to preventing any further loss of life and/or spillage of cargo
- We will accept our legal responsibilities, including the funding of pollution prevention measures and appropriate compensation for pollution damage



Re claims

- We are particularly concerned that individuals do not suffer unnecessary hardship
- We have arranged a local telephone enquiry service. Its number is [.....]
- If this number is engaged and your call is urgent, contact [.....]



Give the agreed answer, add nothing

Every answer in this set has been cleared. Give it in full, add nothing to it, and refer anything it does not cover to Navigate Response.



Use the agreed wording, not your own



No speculation, no blame, no costs



Verify every figure before release



Refer anything else to Navigate Response